



Iceland (2018). The Blue Sharks beat African giant Cameroon to the top spot in its qualifying group and finished the round with seven wins, two draws, and one loss.

Another notable qualifier is South Africa, which overcame a three-point deduction (for fielding an ineligible player earlier) to return to the tournament since memorably hosting it in 2010.

Meanwhile, Mohamed Salah will get a shot at redemption when he returns to the big stage with Egypt after missing out on qualification last time. His former Liverpool teammate, Sadio Mane, also experienced similar success, leading his nation, Senegal, to a third straight appearance at the World Cup.

With the conclusion of the qualifying round, the four best second-placed teams — Cameroon, the Democratic Republic of Congo,

Gabon, and Nigeria — are still in the hunt. They will play two single-match semifinals and a final in Morocco in November, with the winner getting to participate in the inter-continental play-offs in March 2026, where two World Cup berths are up for grabs.

Across the Mediterranean Sea, Thomas Tuchel's England became the first European nation to secure qualification. The Three Lions have had a perfect qualifying campaign so far, and a 5-0 thrashing of Latvia ensured that they would reach a ninth successive major tournament finals, with two games to spare.

However, Portugal will have to wait till the next international window to qualify, after it was held to a 2-2 draw by Hungary. Cristiano Ronaldo, who is bidding to reach a record sixth World Cup, scored a brace, but a stoppage-time equaliser from Dominik Szoboszlai temporarily spoiled Portugal's party.

African flair: Cape Verde qualified for the FIFA World Cup for the first time, becoming the second-smallest nation to play in the global showpiece. AFP

Meanwhile, Norway's Erling Haaland reached yet another milestone after scoring a hat-trick in the game against Israel to become the fastest player to reach 50 international goals. The star striker reached the mark in just 46 games, well ahead of Harry Kane's previous record of 71. Norway is now in pole position to qualify from its group with six wins in six so far, with Italy three points behind in second.

From Asia, Arab powerhouses Saudi Arabia and Qatar also booked their place for next year's tournament in the USA, Canada, and Mexico, after finishing top of their respective qualifying groups.

Results updated as of October 20